



Local AI for Genealogists
Prompt Library — 12
Ready-to-Use Genealogy
Prompts
Seattle Genealogical
Society — AI SIG — July
2026

Genealogy Prompt Library

How to use these prompts:

1. Open LM Studio (or ChatGPT, Claude, or any AI tool)
2. Attach your genealogy document image (for image prompts)
3. Copy the prompt, replace the bracketed placeholders with your details
4. Send and review the output carefully
5. Verify all facts against the original document before recording them

Important: AI can make mistakes. Always verify outputs against your original sources before including them in your research records.

Prompt 1 — Census Analysis

Use for: Any U.S. or international census record image

Act as a professional genealogist analyzing a census record.

I am attaching an image of a [YEAR] [COUNTRY/STATE] census record.

Please:

1. List every person in the household in a table:

Name | Age | Sex | Occupation | Birthplace | Relationship to Head

2. Note any names that are difficult to read and flag them with [?].
 3. Identify what relationships are implied by the household structure, ages, and surnames.
 4. List any additional columns in this census (e.g., real estate value, personal estate, birthplace of parents) and extract those values.
 5. Suggest three additional record types I should search for next to learn more about this household.
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Prompt 2 — Diplomatic Transcription

Use for: Any handwritten record where exact original text matters

Act as a professional archivist producing a diplomatic transcription.

I am attaching an image of a handwritten [RECORD TYPE] from [YEAR].

Please produce a diplomatic transcription following these rules:

- Preserve original spelling exactly, even if incorrect
- Preserve original capitalization exactly
- Preserve original punctuation exactly
- Do not modernize any language or spelling
- Mark uncertain words with [?]
- Mark illegible words with [illegible]
- Mark words you can partially read as [part?]

After the transcription, provide a one-paragraph summary in modern English explaining what the document records.

Prompt 3 — Spanish Document Translation

Use for: Spanish civil registration, church records, letters

Act as a professional genealogist and Spanish translator specializing in 19th-century Latin American records.

I am attaching an image of a [RECORD TYPE] in Spanish from [YEAR/PLACE].

Please:

1. First, produce a diplomatic transcription of the original Spanish text.

Preserve all spelling and accents exactly as written.

Mark uncertain words with [?].

2. Then provide a complete English translation.

– Preserve all personal names exactly as written (do not translate them)

– Preserve all place names exactly as written

– Translate all titles, occupations, and relationship terms

3. After the translation, provide a glossary of any specialized terms, abbreviations, or archaic words used in the document.

4. Note any names or terms that appear to be of indigenous, African,

or non-Spanish origin and explain their likely meaning.

Prompt 4 — Evidence Extraction

Use for: Any document where you want a quick inventory of people, dates, places, and relationships

I am attaching an image of a [RECORD TYPE] from [YEAR].

Please extract all genealogically relevant information and organize it in four tables:

Table 1 – Persons Mentioned

Name (as written) | Role/Relationship | Age (if given) |
Birthplace (if given) | Notes

Table 2 – Dates and Events

Date | Event | Person(s) Involved | Place

Table 3 – Places Mentioned

Place Name | Context (where someone lived, was born, died, married, etc.)

Table 4 – Relationships Stated or Implied

Person A | Relationship | Person B | Source of this claim (stated/ implied)

After the tables, list any facts that suggest additional records I should search for.

Prompt 5 — Evidence Explained Citation

Use for: Formatting a genealogical citation in professional standard

Please create an Evidence Explained citation for the following record:

Record type: [e.g., Death certificate, Marriage register, Census page]

Title or collection: [e.g., "Missouri Death Certificates, 1910–1967"]

Originating creator: [e.g., Missouri Bureau of Vital Records]

Year of document: [YEAR]

Subject names: [Name(s) in the record]

Repository: [Where you found it, e.g., FamilySearch, Ancestry, county courthouse]

URL (if online): [URL if applicable]

Access date: [Date you accessed it]

Item location within collection: [e.g., "entry for John Smith, page 47"]

Format the citation in Evidence Explained style, suitable for use in a published genealogy or formal proof argument.

Prompt 6 — Research Log Entry

Use for: Creating a structured research log entry after analyzing a record

Act as a professional genealogist creating a research log entry.

Based on the document I have been analyzing, please create a research log entry in the following format:

Research Question: [what I was trying to answer]

Date of Research: [today's date]

Repository/Source: [where the record came from]

Record Type: [type of record]

Search Terms Used: [names, dates, places searched]

Results:

- What the record confirms: [list facts confirmed]
- What the record suggests: [list inferences]
- What the record contradicts: [any conflicts with other sources]
- What the record does not answer: [remaining questions]

Source Citation: [Evidence Explained citation]

Next Steps: [what to search for next]

Prompt 7 — Timeline Creation

Use for: After analyzing multiple documents in one conversation

Based on the genealogy records I have shared in this conversation, please create a chronological timeline for [PERSON'S NAME] and their family.

Format each entry as:

YEAR | EVENT | SOURCE DOCUMENT | CONFIDENCE LEVEL

For confidence level, use:

- Certain (explicitly stated in document)
- Probable (strongly implied by the evidence)
- Possible (inferred from context, may need verification)

After the timeline:

1. List the years where we have no records and call this the "gap period."
 2. For each gap period, suggest specific record types that might fill it.
 3. Identify any inconsistencies between the documents (e.g., conflicting ages or dates) and explain how to resolve them.
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Prompt 8 — Document Comparison

Use for: Finding consistencies and conflicts across two or more records

I am going to share [NUMBER] genealogy records about [PERSON/FAMILY].

I have already attached them in this conversation.

Please compare all the records and produce:

1. A consistency table – facts that ALL records agree on:
Fact | Records That Confirm It
2. A conflict table – facts where records disagree:
Fact | Record A says | Record B says | Likely explanation
3. A completeness table – what each record contributes that the others do not:
Unique Information | Found Only In
4. An overall assessment: Which record appears most reliable for establishing
[SPECIFIC FACT]? Explain your reasoning.

5. What additional records would resolve the conflicts you identified?

Prompt 9 — Biography Drafting

Use for: Drafting a publication-ready biographical narrative

Based on the genealogy records we have analyzed in this conversation, please write a biographical narrative about [PERSON'S NAME].

Requirements:

- Write in third person, past tense
- Include **ONLY** facts supported by the documents in this conversation
- After each statement of fact, add a parenthetical source citation:
(1850 Census) or (Marriage Record, 1865)
- Use hedged language for uncertain or inferred facts:
"probably," "apparently," "the record suggests," "it appears that"
- Length: two to three paragraphs
- End with a paragraph titled "What Remains Unknown" identifying the most important unanswered questions and which record types would answer them

This narrative will appear in a published family history.
Accuracy is more important than completeness.

Prompt 10 — Research Planning

Use for: Getting suggested next steps when you are stuck

I am researching [PERSON'S NAME], born approximately [YEAR] in [PLACE], died approximately [YEAR] in [PLACE].

What I have found so far:

[List your existing records and key facts]

What I am trying to determine:

[Your research question – e.g., "Who were this person's parents?"]

Please:

1. Evaluate the records I already have and assess how strong my evidence is.
2. Identify the most important gap in my current evidence.
3. List the five most likely record types to search for next, in priority order.
4. For each record type, tell me:

- Where to find it (online repository, state archives, county courthouse, etc.)
- What it might contain relevant to my research question
- What collection name to search for on FamilySearch or Ancestry

Focus on records that are most likely to survive for [PLACE] in [TIME PERIOD].

Prompt 11 — OCR Cleanup

Use for: Fixing machine-generated OCR text that contains errors

The following text was produced by OCR software scanning a historical document.

It contains errors typical of automated text recognition:

- Letter substitutions (e.g., "rn" read as "m", "li" read as "h")
- Missing spaces or extra spaces
- Incorrect punctuation
- Numbers misread as letters

Please clean up this OCR text, following these rules:

- Correct obvious OCR errors
- Do NOT correct the original spelling or language of the document
- Do NOT modernize archaic words or spellings
- Mark any correction you are uncertain about with [?]
- Preserve all personal names, place names, and dates exactly as best you can read

Original OCR text:
[PASTE OCR TEXT HERE]

Prompt 12 — Book Chapter Summarization

Use for: Extracting genealogically relevant information from county histories, local histories, or genealogy books

I am attaching an image of a page from a [BOOK TITLE/TYPE] published in [YEAR], covering [PLACE/TOPIC].

Please:

1. Identify every personal name mentioned on this page.
For each name, note: context (what are they mentioned for?), dates mentioned, and any family relationships stated.
2. Identify every place name mentioned.
3. Extract any genealogical facts: births, deaths, marriages, migrations, property, occupations, or military service.

4. Note any sources or other books cited that I could follow up.
 5. Rate the genealogical research value of this page:
High (specific names/dates), Medium (general context), or
Low (narrative with no personal details). Explain briefly.
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Tips for Better Prompts

Be specific about the time period and place. The AI performs better when it knows the historical context.

Tell the AI what format you want. Tables are easier to copy into research software than paragraphs.

Ask for confidence levels. “Mark uncertain readings with [?]” produces more honest outputs.

Give the AI its role. Starting with “Act as a professional genealogist...” improves results.

Ask for what you will do with the output. “This will appear in a published family history” signals that accuracy matters.

Verify everything. AI output is a starting point, not a finished product.
